

Parallel lives

The character of Charles Foster Kane was a brutal portrait of newspaper magnate William Randolph Hearst. Determined to shut the movie down, Hearst had negatives burned and waged a campaign to discredit Welles.

Kane vs Hearst



Kane owns the *New York Inquirer*; the *New York Journal* is in Hearst's media empire



The fictional Kane aspires to be US president, as did the real-life Hearst



Kane lives on the vast Xanadu estate in Florida; Hearst lived at Hearst Castle, California



Kane collects "enough for ten museums"; Hearst amassed thousands of art objects



Kane has a mistress, singer Susan Alexander; Hearst's was actress Marion Davies



Kane's mother finds a gold mine; Hearst was the son of a gold-mining millionaire

extensive creative partnership with Alfred Hitchcock. But more than anything, the movie's brilliance is due to its script, which Welles cowrote with screenwriter Herman J. Mankiewicz. Although Mankiewicz's exact contribution has been disputed, often by Welles, the movie does bear extensive traces of Mankiewicz's satirical style: at one particularly loaded

moment, having his affair discovered by his wife, Kane simply says, dryly, "I had no idea you had this flair for melodrama, Emily."

Parallels with Hearst

Despite the arguments over who wrote what, it is agreed that it was Mankiewicz who first came up with the idea for the movie. Having attained some success as a writer in the silent era, Mankiewicz became a sought-after script doctor, and it was in this capacity that he came to know the press tycoon William Randolph Hearst and his mistress, the movie actress Marion Davies. Although everyone denied it—including Hearst, who behaved with a very Kane-like determination to destroy the movie and its makers' reputations—the parallels between Hearst and Kane were

Welles's eye for publicity was evident in the posters for the original release, which talked up the movie without giving anything away.

all too clear. It is a common fallacy that the movie flopped on release (it was the sixth-highest grossing movie of the year and nominated for nine Oscars), but a blanket ban by Hearst's vast media empire ensured that its success was short-lived. Although it satirizes several cherished ideals, including the American dream (Kane sees no irony in being an autocratic capitalist who claims to fight for the common man), *Citizen Kane* does have sympathy for its subject. With Kane dead and Thompson unable to finish his quest, Welles's camera takes viewers through the clutter of Xanadu, where Kane's vast and gaudy art collection is being packed away.

Finally, the shot settles on the sled, named Rosebud, that Kane was playing with in the snow outside his parents' shack. No one knows but us, and Kane, that this sled represents the key moment of his life: the moment he lost his innocence and happiness. ■

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The film's style was made with the ease and boldness and resource of one who controls and is not controlled by his medium.

Dilys Powell
The Sunday Times, 1941

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